



A colorful Buddhist mural from the Yungang caves, which were begun under the Northern Wei c. 450.

THE EASTERN JIN DYNASTY IN CHINA HAD ENDED IN 420, with Gongti's abdication. His successor, Song Wudi (r. 420–22), a former fisherman, had risen to become a general and **founded the Liu Song dynasty**. He strengthened the southern kingdom's northern borders against the barbarian tribes, but under his son Wendi (r. 424–53), the northerners captured Luoyang in 424 before, some 25 years later, **besieging the** Liu Song capital of **Nanking**. Although Song Wudi had strengthened the central bureaucracy, the growing power and wealth of the **Buddhist and Daoist monasteries** weakened the economic basis of the state. Wendi's successors were weak and by 479 the Liu Song were overthrown by the short-lived **Qi dynasty** (479–502).

Meanwhile, in northern China, the **Sixteen Kingdoms** had been united under the Toba Wei (a group of Turkic nomads), who founded the **Northern Wei dynasty** (386–534). The Northern Wei ruled over northern China, until its split into two in the early 6th century following a revolt against the imposition of Chinese dress and language on the Wei nomads.

In Europe, the Western Roman Empire continued to lose ground, as barbarians occupied more and more of its territory. In the 420s the **Visigoths under Theodoric**

(r. 418–51) occupied sections of the Mediterranean shore of Gaul, before they were pushed back southwest in 430. Around this time a new group of barbarians, the **Huns**, began to menace the empire. This nomadic group from Central Asia, whose pressure from the rear on the Goths had been indirectly responsible for the crisis of 378 in the Balkans, had since moved farther west. In 424, the Roman general **Aëtius recruited a force of Huns** to help him bolster the cause of John, a usurper raised up at Rome after the death of Honorius in 423. Aëtius continued to use the Huns into the late 420s to secure his power base and his appointment as patrician (the most senior post in the late Roman Empire) in 429. **In 435**, he was able to call on them to aid an **attack on the Burgundians** who had raided across the lower Rhine; these were soundly



Northern Wei horse
The art of the Northern Wei often evoked their nomadic origins, as in this beautiful terra-cotta horse.

“THE WORLD IS PASSING AWAY... LOSING ITS GRIP, THE WORLD IS SHORT OF BREATH.”

St. Augustine of Hippo, theologian and philosopher, from *Sermons* 81, 8

defeated and thereafter confined to a region to the northwest of Italy.

These were all just temporary successes, however, as the **area controlled** by the Western Roman emperors **was diminishing steadily**. The loss of almost all of North Africa to the Vandals in 429–39 (and of Sicily in 440), of northern Gaul to the Franks by 450, of southwest Gaul to the Visigoths after 418, and of all save a few isolated outposts in Spain by the 430s meant the remaining strongholds in Italy and southeastern Gaul **could not provide enough tax revenue** to support armies to reconquer the lost provinces. The long reign of **Valentinian III** (r. 425–55) in the Western Roman Empire **did not provide any stability** as he ascended to the throne as a child and never asserted himself until

the very end, when he had **Aëtius**, the Western Empire's last effective general, **murdered**.

The **barbarians** who settled on the former Roman territories began gradually to **establish kingdoms of their own**, notably the Franks in northern Gaul and the Visigoths in southwest Gaul and Spain. In **Britain**, the situation **was rather different**, since the province had rebelled against Rome rather than being subject to barbarian conquest. In a bygone era, the Roman army might have been expected to reassert its control there, but with the empire increasingly dependent on barbarian troops fighting under their own commanders, there was virtually no army left to retake it. The Britons were left to their own devices. It seems that some Roman institutions survived for a while; in 429 Bishop Germanus of Auxerre visited the island and found men bearing Roman titles. But **barbarian raiders**—attracted by the weak British defenses and the lack of a central political authority to counter them—**came in increasing numbers**. Around 446, the leading men of Britain addressed a desperate letter to



FLAVIUS AËTIUS
(c. 395–454)

Born of nobility in Moesia (modern Bulgaria), Aëtius spent time from 408 in the royal court of the Huns. He used these contacts to gain influence and rose to further prominence in the late 420s. The deaths of patricians Felix (in 430) and Boniface (in 433) left him with unrivaled dominance. He shored up the empire's position, and in 451 he scored a notable victory against Attila the Hun. In 454 he was murdered by Valentinian III himself.

Aëtius, appealing for aid. No reply was sent to these “groans of the Britons.” and within a few years the **Angle, Saxon, and Jutish raiders** began to occupy parts of the former Roman province.

